

ROCKY MAKKAD

don't find someone now, I'll go past the marriageable age and be alone forever. But not one guy I have dated has been keen on marriage. It is disappointing, and I feel I am the one who is doing something wrong," says Megha Kapur, a Delhi University graduate. never mind that she's only 19!

Many are choosing to become dating coaches today because they sense this growing turmoil. One dating coach pegged his monthly earnings as Rs 3.5 lakh—double what he was making at an MNC in Mumbai. However, for some, it is simply an interest in relationships that leads them to adopt it as a profession.

Prathamesh Kulkarni, 34, a relationship coach in Mumbai, decided two years back to shift from his marketing role to help people—both single and committed—lead healthy love lives. He has studied from TISS and has certification from Gottman Institute. Based on research by American psychologist John Gottman, the institute trains counsellors who want to specialise in couple relationships. "I felt that there was a lot of misunderstanding about relationships. I wanted to offer a solution which adopts a research-based approach," says Kulkarni. "I focus on the factors and behaviour patterns that are causing unhappiness and disconnection in relationships. All interventions are created based on discussion with clients, as opposed to just giving advice. I didn't want to offer 'coaching' without a thorough knowledge on relationships," he adds. A year old in the profession, he says his clientele is growing.

However, some relationship coaches rely not on formal training but on experience and instinct. Rukayya Zirapur started coaching when she was 20. While it was a struggle to have people take her seriously at first, she says she has built her reputation over the past five years on the back of hard work and giving clients a space to express themselves freely. "I have an instinct for emotions and understanding people," she says. Bottling things up, not communicating them, feels Zirapur, is a common relationship-breaker. "Simple things like talking after a fight to resolve a problem rather than putting your partner through guilt or the silent treatment can make all the difference," she adds. The behaviour she helps clients adopt seems straightforward—apologising, not invalidating someone else's emotions and experiences—but most people often don't know how or when to put them into practice.

Dating/ relationship coaches have their work cut out. A 2022 report by data.ai pointed out that India is the fifth fastest growing market for dating app spending in the world. Indians spent Rs 254 crore more on dating apps in 2022 than they did in 2021. But such thirst for love is not indicative of fulfilment. Experts say isolation and unhappiness has grown in Indian society. India may have one of the lowest divorce rates, but two million Indians have joined the extra-marital dating site Gleeden—one-fifth of its global user base.

"I think we have less emotional maturity than before. Young people get emotionally triggered and confused easily. The capacity to separate emotion from oneself and make pragmatic

FROM THE COACHING MANUAL

How to be emotionally desirable, as per dating coaches' advice

SET BOUNDARIES: They help protect your sensitivities and your sense of self-worth

REGULATE EMOTIONS: Learning to not be in extremes of emotions, so that decisions come from a place of logic

POWER OF EXPRESSION: Not being able to say how you feel and what you expect can make the other person think you are cold and uninterested

UNDERSTANDING WOMEN: Many men are unable to strike the balance between traditional stereotypes and modern views of women

HEALTHY FLIRTING: The ultimate ice-breaker

LISTENING: Being able to give your partner a safe space to speak is crucial

APOLOGISING: Genuine apologies do not deflect blame and come with follow-up action as remedies

COMFORTABLE DRESSING: Fancy attire can be stressful. Coaches emphasise comfort dressing instead

REDUCING FEAR: Be it fear of commitment, expression, coming across as inappropriate–they stop you from connecting with others and have to be overcome